

Earthquake Safety: A Short Field Guide

1. Preparing before an earthquake

Keep an emergency kit ready before shaking ever starts. Store at least four liters of water per person per day, and hold enough for three days. Keep the kit near an exit so you can reach it quickly in the dark.

2. During the shaking

The moment the ground moves, Drop, Cover, and Hold On. Drop to your hands and knees, take cover under a sturdy table, and hold on until the shaking stops. Stay away from windows and anything that can fall on you. Do not run outside while the ground is still moving.

3. After the shaking stops

Expect aftershocks; they can continue for days or even weeks and are sometimes strong enough to bring down already-weakened buildings. Turn off the gas only if you smell gas or hear a hissing sound, because shutting it off needlessly can leave you without heat for a long time.

4. If you are trapped

If you are trapped under rubble, tap steadily on a pipe or a wall so rescuers can hear you. Do not shout unless you have no other option: shouting wastes energy and makes you breathe in dangerous dust. Cover your mouth with cloth to filter the air.

5. The emergency kit

A basic kit holds water, non-perishable food, a flashlight, spare batteries, a whistle, a dust mask, and a first-aid box. Add any personal medicines and copies of important documents in a waterproof bag.